A Snicker of Magic

By Natalie Lloyd

(Pg 137-138)

The 5 Most Interesting Facts about Myself

- I am Felicity Pickle. My first name stands for "wondrous joy." My [last] name is Pickle and it stands for all my people behind me and ahead of me.
- I live in a town that used to be full of magic. I think there's still magic here. It's just been playing hide-and-seek for a very long time. I want to stay forever. **(Pg 5)** [It's] a proper place to call home.
- My best friend's name is Jonah Pickett. **(Pg 145)** ***Best*** Friend, not just a friend, a ***best*** friend.
- Because of Jonah Pickett, I signed up for the Duel. Even though I would still rather floss with barbed wire than participate.
- [The morning I signed up for the Duel], **(Pg 8)** I saw my first word of the day: ***Believe***. Something wonderful was about to happen to me. I didn't know what, or why, or how. But I believed.

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INTRODUCTION

Midnight Gulch used to be a magical place, a town where people could sing up thunderstorms and dance up sunflowers. But that was long ago, before a curse of the Brothers Threadbare drove the magic away. Twelve-year-old Felicity knows all about things like that; her nomadic mother is cursed with a wandering heart. But when she arrives in Midnight Gulch, her luck may be about to change. A "word collector", Felicity sees words everywhere -- shining above strangers, tucked into church eves, and tangled up in dog's ears - and Midnight Gulch is the first place she's ever seen the word "home". Will any words convince Mama not to move again? Felicity wants to stay here forever, but first she will need to bring back the magic, breaking the spell that's been cast over the town in the novel A Snicker of Magic by Natalie Lloyd.

(Pg 7) Mama liked to say that us Pickles were nomads. Sweet gypsies. Adventure seekers. **(Pg 67)** She's always looking for a reason to leave. No matter where we go. **(Pg 30)** It'd take a miracle to make a bunch of gypsy Pickles finally settle down. A big miracle . . . or a little bit of magic.

JONAH: (Pg 67) "Maybe that's why you have to do the Duel. Maybe if your mama sees you competing in the talent show . . . If she sees how happy you are in

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Midnight Gulch, then she'll want to stay for a while. **(Pg 37)** Felicity Pickle, I'm going to help you win the talent show . . . Miss Lawson's Duel.

FELICITY: I appreciate it, but I have no talent. Except well . . . **(Pg 13)** I see words everywhere, all around me, all the time. **(Pg 37-39)** I collect them. Words come in all sorts of shapes: stars, spaceships, pretzel words. Some words glow and some words dance. I know how to catch words and keep them. **(Pg 9)** I'm not sure how it works. I can't be the only word collector in the whole world, but I've never met anybody else who has the knack.

JONAH: **(Pg 134)** I think your word collecting is a snicker of magic . . .

FELICITY: Word collecting's not magic. It's just a quirk . . .

JONAH: The Brothers Threadbare, **(Pg 18)** the most famous duo ever to call Midnight Gulch their home, **(Pg 134)** probably thought that way. Until they saw what their music did to people., how it made them dance. Made them happy.

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(Pg 135) The only magic I was interested in was the kind that would make Mama stay put. I'd give anything to find a snicker of magic like that.

TRANSITION

Jonah took Felicity around all parts of town, helping her collect stories and words from the townsfolk – Gathering information for the talent show, best known as The Duel. But it was Miss Lawson, their teacher who told them the story of The Brothers Threadbare and the magical place that was once Midnight Gulch.

(Pg 19-22) "Like most people, the Brothers Threadbare were simple, easygoing folk . . . who just so happened to have a little magic in their veins. Their names were Stone and Berry Weatherly, farm boys. The Weatherly magic was a particularly wonderful kind, because their magic had to do with music. Whenever Stone played his guitar or at the first strum of Berry's banjo, the whole world seemed to dance. They always started their concerts with a few magic tricks.

But soon, the brothers realized people were more interested in their magic tricks than in their singing. So they focused on the magic. But sadly, their fame and

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fortune became a dividing line between them. The brothers became so jealous of one another that they finally decided to have a duel. Whoever won, they decided, could keep all the money and fame and fortune they'd earned. But the loser would be cursed forever with a wandering heart.

They dueled for three whole days – Finally Berry cast the winning spell. And poor Stone Weatherly. He let town. Soon after he left, Berry discovered that, without his brother, his magic didn't work anyhow. Eventually he disappeared from town, too. Midnight Gulch used to be their favorite secret, their favorite place, but [it] didn't feel like home anymore. People started leaving, breaking apart from their families and heading out in search of what they'd lost.

(Pg 89) [Oliver, the owner of Dr. Zook's Ice Cream Shop, told us]: "Most people in this town only know the story of the Duel. They don't know about the day Stone Weatherly came back to Midnight Gulch, [looking for his brother.] **(Pg 91)** [He] didn't stay here long. He was cursed with a wandering heart and had to keep moving

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along. He was such a lonely man. **(Pg 95)** They both spent the rest of their time trying to find each other, trying to break the curse.

"Cursed to wander through the night, till cords align, and all's made right.

Where sweet amends are made and spoken, shadows dance, the curse is broken."

(Pg 158-159) [It was finally in talking to Aunt Cleo that we found out that] Stone Weatherly was [actually] my "no-good-lowdown-deadbeat-drifter great-great-grandfather". And that means it [isn't] magic we had in our veins. All we've got is the curse.

Stone Weatherly lost the duel. And because he lost, he had to leave town and live out that curse for the rest of his days. He couldn't set roots in any place. He was cursed with a restless soul.

Like Mama. **(Pg 127)** Mama was always thinking of going, and never staying put.

(Pg 253) I was sick of always beginning. I just wanted to be. ***Stop settling in here***, I told my heart.

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Pickles always leave. Soon enough, there'd be a new town. A new first day of school.

(Pg 221) You don't have to leave to find a new beginning, Mama. You can begin again exactly where you are. But me telling her wouldn't matter. Mama had to see that we were home for herself.

(Pg 274) [The day of the Duel] I Watched my whole family lodge themselves in the middle row, where they could see me and cheer for me when I took the stage. [And I realized] I could do anything if they were with me. My fears were monster big. But their love for me was bigger. **(Pg 280)** And suddenly I knew [what the curse of the Theadbare Brothers meant] There is no magic in the world more powerful than love. If you're brave enough to love, and forgive . . . there's no curse in the world that has any power over you.

(Pg 281-282) [And so I shared these words at the Duel:] "Once upon a time, here in this place where I'm talking, two magicians made a mess of things. People say that when they left town, they took all the magic with them. There's still a snicker of magic left, but there's

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more sorrow, now, than joy. People leave here, and never come back. They don't want to stay here. They don't want to end up here, because this doesn't feel like home anymore.

In the end, I don't think [the Brothers Threadbare] even cared about the magic. Instead of being so hateful, instead of dooming each other to wander off along . . . they should have said the words that mattered most of all. Their words were more powerful than any magic trick they ever did.

I think the Brothers Threadbare had forgotten all about who they really were. They were family. I think if they had to do it over, I think they would have said ***"Sorry for what I did to you."*** And they would have said ***"I love you."*** Maybe if you say those words, maybe if you believe them, no curse in the world has any power over you.

I've collected whole constellations of words. But these words are my favorite: ***Mama***, [Aunt] ***Cleo***, [Uncle] ***Boone***, [sister] ***Frannie***, [Jonah], [my dog] ***Biscuit***. I wouldn't know anything about love if it weren't for them.

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No matter what happens, or what I do, or how far apart we are, I know they love me. And if you say, "I love you," and you mean it, then love makes up for a whole lifetime of mistakes. That's some kind of magic."

(Pg 283) "Chords align, and all's made right."

(Pg 298) [And just like that, after that day, we stayed in Midnight Gulch.[The curse [that kept Mama a wanderer[was broken.

(Pg 306-307) It's so weird how life is full of moving around - people coming and going, people passing by each other all day long. You never know which person's going to steal your heart. You never know which place is going to settle your soul. All you can do is look. And hope. And believe.

(Pg 309) I'm convinced Midnight Gulch can't be the only magical town in the world. I bet there's a snicker of magic on every street, in every old building, every broken heart, every word of a story. Maybe it's hidden away and you need to look harder for it. Or maybe the magic is right there, right in front of you, and all you have to do is . . . ***believe***.

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